

BROTHERSFIELD MENNONITE BRETHREN CHURCH

Parker, South Dakota

Back in 1874 hundreds of Low German Mennonites immigrated from South Russia to the prairies of Turner and Hutchinson counties in South Dakota. Included with these immigrants were several families of Mennonite Brethren background settling in Brothersfield Township in Turner County. They were the Tobias Unruh, Heinrich Adrian, Peter Engbrecht, John Boese, and Diedrich Loewen families. Henry and Tobias Kunkel and the Brandts came in 1875. Soon they were seeking out other Christians for fellowship. For three years they worshipped in the already established Evangelical Church.

As more Mennonite Brethren settlers arrived, the group became large enough to start holding meetings in their homes. On May 27, 1877 the group formally organized a church, electing Cornelius Günther (Guenther) as their leader and Brother David Funk as the assistant. They called their congregation the "Brothersfield or Brüderfeld Mennonite Brethren Church." The first was built on the John John's quarter located in the SE ¼ of Section 20, Brothersfield Township, four miles north of Parker, South Dakota.

The same year, 1877, Brother Heinrich Adrian was elected minister and served the congregation until he left for Kansas in 1902. Jacob C. Thomas, a very capable and energetic young man, was the first choir leader.

In 1878 they decided to expand their fellowship, so they chose Heinrich Adrian and Isaac Loewen to begin the church planting. By 1881 these brethren were meeting with groups in four locations: Brothersfield Church, Silver Lake Church, Wittenberg Township at a spot several miles southwest of the present Wolf Creek Colony, and at Rosefield Township at a location called "Emmanuel's Creek" south of Marion.

The young Brothersfield congregation met with some trials in the mid 1880's when a number of their members left to join another denomination. However, after a series of evangelistic meetings, new converts joined the church and many of the former members returned.

On September 29, 1897 the Brothersfield group was incorporated in the State of South Dakota under the name of the "Mennonite Brethren Church, Parker." The trustees at the time were Henry Adrian, John Boese, Peter Adrian, Henry Unruh, and Ludwig Seibel.

Membership continued to decline over the years as families left to farm larger tracts of land because of the needs of their growing families. The largest group left for Hepburn, Saskatchewan, Canada responding to the offer of Homestead Land between the North and South Saskatchewan River. Several returned to Buhler, Kansas and Mountain Lake, Minnesota. Others settled around the Silver Lake area and joined the church there. By 1913 the last of the Brothersfield Church families had left the community. The church building, which so often resounded with "the Spirit of God in heaven" was sold in 1912. This building can still be seen today for it is now the remodeled home of Mr. and Mrs. Marlin Davis of Parker who live four miles west, one mile south and one-fourth mile east of Pumpkin Center on the Vermillion River.

The Brothersfield Church left many reminders of its early role in church planting. The group in Hepburn, Saskatchewan organized a Mennonite Brethren Church and called it the Brothersfield Mennonite Brethren Church. The congregation at Wittenberg moved to Harvey, North Dakota and started a Mennonite Brethren Church. Silver Lake Mennonite Brethren Church benefited by the addition of the Brothersfield families who settled there. Reverend Heinrich Adrian, after serving the Brothersfield Church for 26 years, continued his ministry in Buhler, Kansas for another 24 years.

Although the Brothersfield Church was shortlived yet it managed to carry out God's mission for His church and that is to plant, to water, but then trust God to give the increase.



The Brothersfield Mennonite Brethren Church built in 1877 four miles north of Parker. This building is now the remodeled home of Mr. and Mrs. Marlin Davis, Parker.

119

SILVER LAKE MENNONITE BRETHREN CHURCH

Marion, South Dakota

The Silver Lake Mennonite Brethren Church began as a mission church of the Brothersfield Mennonite Brethren Church of Parker, South Dakota. The Parker Mennonite Brethren Church was organized on May 27, 1877, by settlers who had arrived as early as 1874.

Two brethren, Heinrich Adrian and Isaac Loewen, were chosen to begin the early church planting. When they arrived in the Silver Lake area they discovered that as early as 1878 a lady, Katherine Taske, was holding Sunday School and small worship services each Sunday. These services were held in Mrs. Taske's forty-foot-long home located just west of the present Harley Thomas farm. The two men were invited to preach and thus begins the history of the Silver Lake Mennonite Brethren Church. This first meeting place still stands as a granary on the Harley Thomas farm six and a half miles west of Marion, South Dakota.

Sometime later this small group divided because of differences over Biblical interpretation. One group joined other families moving to Silver Lake from the Brothersfield Church. By 1881 Heinrich Adrian, ordained to the ministry October 30, 1881, and Brother Loewen were meeting with groups of believers in their homes. Each gathering location was called a "Station." During the mid 1880's the group was joined by additional members from the Brothersfield congregation. The Silver Lake congregation was rapidly becoming the major Mennonite Brethren Church in South Dakota.

In 1891 the first church building was erected on property formerly owned by Peter and Kathrina Fast. It was deeded to "The Mennonite Brüder Gemeinde" on May 27, 1891 for the sum of \$10.00. Construction of the newly-acquired site began the same year, 1891. It was on the western shore of Silver Lake across from Highway 81. The simple one-story wood-frame structure measured 24 x 40 feet and was adjoined by a summer kitchen. The cost came to only \$400.00.

According to one source, the church had its first baptismal service on March 28, 1882. Three of the baptismal candidates were Mr. and Mrs. Cornelius Thomas and their elder son Jacob (Cornelius was the father to Mrs. Tobias Deckert and Druggist Thomas of Marion). The first funeral in the church was that of Mrs. Ben Adrian.

Reverend Peter Adrian from the Brothersfield Mennonite Brethren Church, Parker, South Dakota was serving the small group as supply pastor as circumstances permitted until 1889. Mr. and Mrs. Heinrich Adrian, Mr. and Mrs. Jacob J. Adrian, Sr., Mr. and Mrs. Gerhart Goosen, and Mr. and Mrs. Heinrich Goertzen joined the church.



The first church building of the Silver Lake Mennonite Brethren congregation was erected in 1891 on the western shore of Silver Lake. The building was adjoined by a summer kitchen.



Rev. Heinrich P. Unruh, first minister of the Silver Lake Church